

LLMs & VLMs course

Implementing a GPT model from scratch

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Contents

From attention to a full GPT

Layer normalization

Feed forward network with GELU

Shortcut connections

The transformer block

Coding the GPT model

Generating text

Summary and exercises

Roadmap

From attention to a full GPT

Layer normalization

Feed forward network with GELU

Shortcut connections

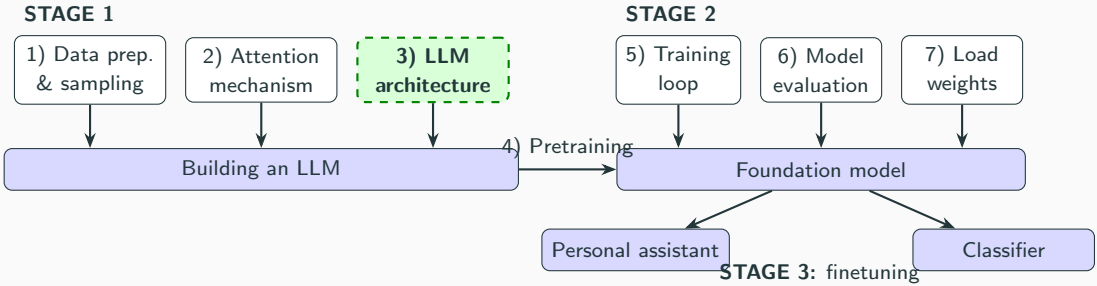
The transformer block

Coding the GPT model

Generating text

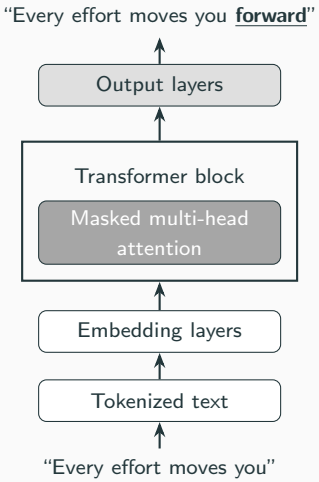
Summary and exercises

Where are we?



Last session: **multi-head attention**. Today: the **other building blocks** and how to assemble them into a GPT-like model.

A mental model of a GPT model



- GPT = **G**enerative **P**retrained **T**ransformer.
- Generates new text **one token at a time**.
- Despite its size, the architecture is simple: most components are **repeated**.
- Today: the **transformer block** and the full model.

Target: GPT-2 small (124M parameters)

- Radford et al., *Language Models are Unsupervised Multitask Learners* (2019).
- Weights are **publicly available** $\Rightarrow$ we can load them later.
- GPT-3 has the same architecture, scaled from 1.5B to **175B** parameters.
- GPT-2 runs on a laptop; GPT-3 would take $\sim$355 years to train on a single V100.

Model	Params	Layers
GPT-2 small	124M	12
GPT-2 medium	355M	24
GPT-2 large	774M	36
GPT-2 XL	1,558M	48
GPT-3	175B	96

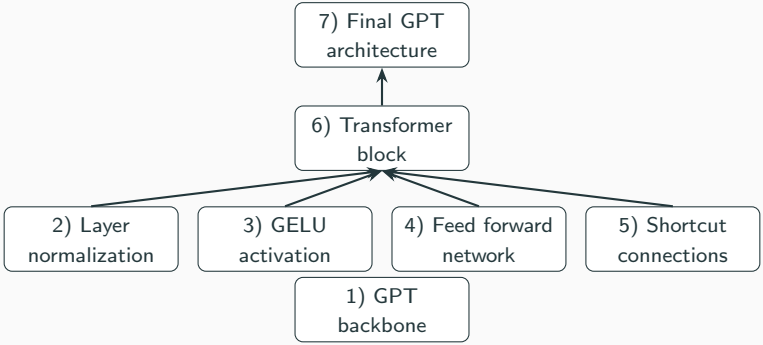
Parameters
Trainable weights. A 2048×2048 layer already has 4,194,304 parameters.

The model configuration

```
GPT_CONFIG_124M = {
        "vocab_size": 50257,     # Vocabulary size
        "context_length": 1024,  # Context length
        "emb_dim": 768,          # Embedding dim
        "n_heads": 12,           # Attention heads
        "n_layers": 12,          # Transformer blocks
        "drop_rate": 0.1,        # Dropout rate
        "qkv_bias": False        # Query-Key-Value bias
}
```

- `vocab_size`: BPE tokenizer vocabulary (Ch. 2).
- `context_length`: max. input tokens (positional embeddings).
- `emb_dim`: each token $\rightarrow$ 768-d vector.
- `n_heads`: heads in multi-head attention.
- `n_layers`: number of transformer blocks.
- `drop_rate`: 10% of hidden units dropped.
- `qkv_bias`: bias in W^Q, W^K, W^V (off, as in modern LLMs).

Plan for this session



We start with a **placeholder backbone** to see the big picture, then fill in blocks 2–5, assemble block 6, and finish with the full GPT (7).

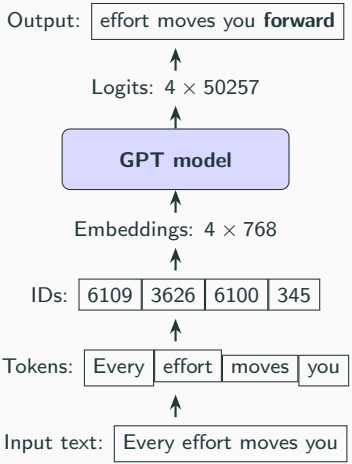
Step 1: A placeholder GPT backbone

```
class DummyGPTModel(nn.Module):
def __init__(self, cfg):
super().__init__()
self.tok_emb = nn.Embedding(cfg["vocab_size"], cfg["emb_dim"])
self.pos_emb = nn.Embedding(cfg["context_length"], cfg["emb_dim"])
self.drop_emb = nn.Dropout(cfg["drop_rate"])
self.trf_blocks = nn.Sequential(
*[DummyTransformerBlock(cfg) for _ in range(cfg["n_layers"])])
self.final_norm = DummyLayerNorm(cfg["emb_dim"])
self.out_head = nn.Linear(cfg["emb_dim"], cfg["vocab_size"], bias=False)

def forward(self, in_idx):
batch_size, seq_len = in_idx.shape
tok_embeds = self.tok_emb(in_idx)
pos_embeds = self.pos_emb(torch.arange(seq_len, device=in_idx.device))
x = self.drop_emb(tok_embeds + pos_embeds)
x = self.trf_blocks(x)
x = self.final_norm(x)
return self.out_head(x)          # logits
```

`DummyTransformerBlock` and `DummyLayerNorm` simply return `x` for now.

Data flow in and out of a GPT model



- Tokenize a batch of 2 texts with `tiktoken` (GPT-2 BPE).
- Input shape: `[2, 4]`
- Output shape: `[2, 4, 50257]`
- One **logit vector per token**, one dimension per vocabulary entry.
- The last row should predict the **next** word.

Roadmap

From attention to a full GPT

Layer normalization

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Summary and exercises

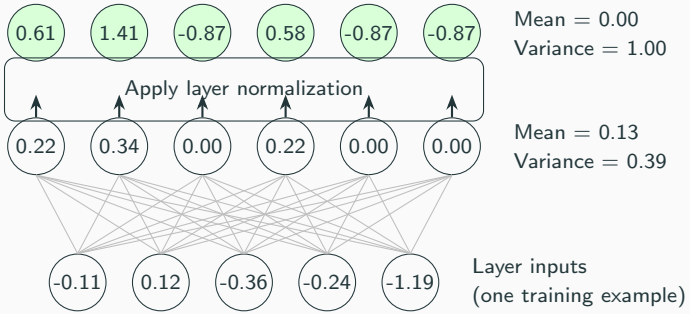
Why normalize?

- Deep networks suffer from **vanishing / exploding gradients** $\Rightarrow$ unstable training.
- **Idea:** rescale the activations of a layer to **mean 0** and **variance 1**.
- Faster convergence and more reliable training.

$$\text{LayerNorm}(\mathbf{x}) = \gamma \odot \frac{\mathbf{x} - \mu}{\sqrt{\sigma^2 + \epsilon}} + \beta, \qquad \mu = \frac{1}{d}\sum_{i=1}^{d} x_i, \quad \sigma^2 = \frac{1}{d}\sum_{i=1}^{d}(x_i - \mu)^2$$

- Computed over the **feature (embedding) dimension** of each token.
- γ (*scale*) and β (*shift*) are **trainable**.
- ϵ (e.g. 10^{-5}) avoids division by zero.

Layer normalization: an example



Computing mean and variance in PyTorch

```
torch.
    manual_seed
    (123)

batch_example
     =
    torch
    .
    randn
    (2,
    5)
layer =
    nn.
    Sequential
    (nn.
    Linear
    (5,
    6),
    nn.
    ReLU
```

- `dim=-1`: last dimension (one statistic **per row**).
- `dim=0`: one statistic **per column**.
- With 3D tensors `[batch, tokens, emb]`, `dim=-1` still normalizes each token's embedding.

	Mean	Variance
Before	0.1324 / 0.2170	0.0231 / 0.0398
After	≈ 0	1.0

A `LayerNorm` module

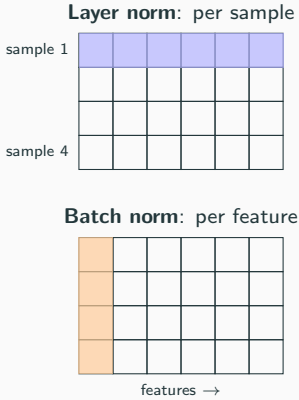
```
class LayerNorm(nn.Module):
def __init__(self, emb_dim):
super().__init__()
self.eps = 1e-5
self.scale = nn.Parameter(torch.ones(emb_dim))    #
    gamma
self.shift = nn.Parameter(torch.zeros(emb_dim))   #
    beta

def forward(self, x):
mean = x.mean(dim=-1, keepdim=True)
var = x.var(dim=-1, keepdim=True, unbiased=False)
norm_x = (x - mean) / torch.sqrt(var + self.eps)
return self.scale * norm_x + self.shift
```

Biased variance (`unbiased=False`)

Divides by n instead of $n-1$ (no Bessel's correction). Negligible for large n, and it matches GPT-2's original TensorFlow implementation $\Rightarrow$ compatible with pretrained weights.

Layer norm vs. batch norm



- **Batch norm** normalizes across the **batch** dimension.
- **Layer norm** normalizes across the **feature** dimension.
- Layer norm is **independent of the batch size**:
  - Works with batch size 1 at inference.
  - Better for distributed training and constrained hardware.

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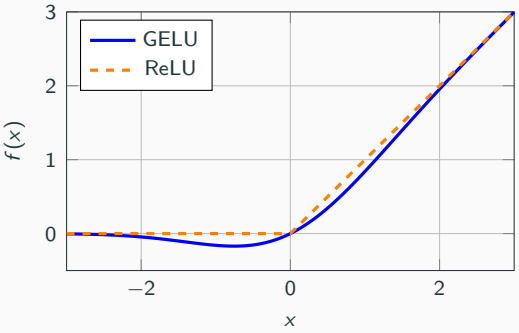
Generating text

Summary and exercises

The GELU activation function

- LLMs use smoother activations than ReLU: **GELU** and **SwiGLU**.
- Exact definition: $\mathrm{GELU}(x) = x\,\Phi(x)$, with Φ the standard Gaussian CDF.
- GPT-2 uses the cheaper approximation:

$$\mathrm{GELU}(x) \approx 0.5\,x\left(1+\tanh\left[\sqrt{\tfrac{2}{\pi}}\left(x+0.044715\,x^3\right)\right]\right)$$



GELU vs. ReLU

ReLU

- Piecewise linear: $\max(0, x)$.
- Sharp corner at $0 \Rightarrow$ harder optimization in very deep networks.
- Zero output (and gradient) for every negative input.

GELU

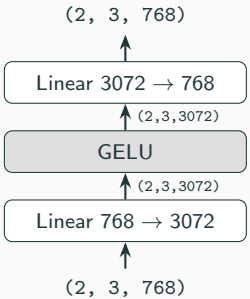
- Smooth and non-linear everywhere.
- Allows more nuanced parameter updates.
- Small **non-zero** output for negative inputs $\Rightarrow$ those neurons still contribute to learning.

The `FeedForward` module

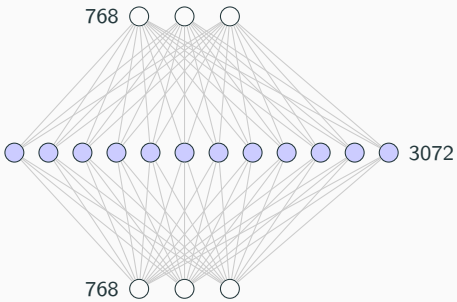
```
class GELU(nn.Module):
def forward(self, x):
return 0.5 * x * (1 + torch.
      tanh(
torch.sqrt(torch.tensor(2.0 /
      torch.pi)) *
(x + 0.044715 * torch.pow(x,
      3))))

class FeedForward(nn.Module):
def __init__(self, cfg):
super().__init__()
self.layers = nn.Sequential(
nn.Linear(cfg["emb_dim"], 4 *
      cfg["emb_dim"]),
GELU(),
nn.Linear(4 * cfg["emb_dim"],
      cfg["emb_dim"]))

def forward(self, x):
return self.layers(x)
```



Expand, activate, contract



- First layer **expands** by a factor of 4 ($768 \to 3072$).
- GELU adds non-linearity in the larger space $\Rightarrow$ **richer representations**.
- Second layer **contracts** back to 768.
- Same input and output shape $\Rightarrow$ blocks can be **stacked** without adjusting dimensions.
- Works for any batch size and number of tokens.

Roadmap

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Generating text

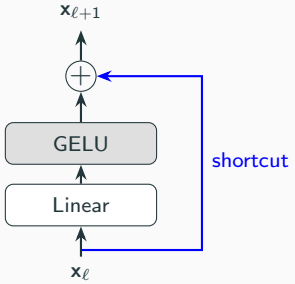
Summary and exercises

Shortcut (skip / residual) connections

- Proposed in **ResNets** (computer vision) to fight **vanishing gradients**.
- Gradients shrink as they propagate backward $\Rightarrow$ early layers barely learn.
- A shortcut **adds the input of a layer to its output**:

$$\mathbf{x}_{\ell+1} = \mathbf{x}_\ell + f_\ell(\mathbf{x}_\ell)$$

- Creates an alternative, shorter path for the gradient: $\frac{\partial \mathbf{x}_{\ell+1}}{\partial \mathbf{x}_\ell} = I + \frac{\partial f_\ell}{\partial \mathbf{x}_\ell}$



Experiment: a 5-layer network with and without shortcuts

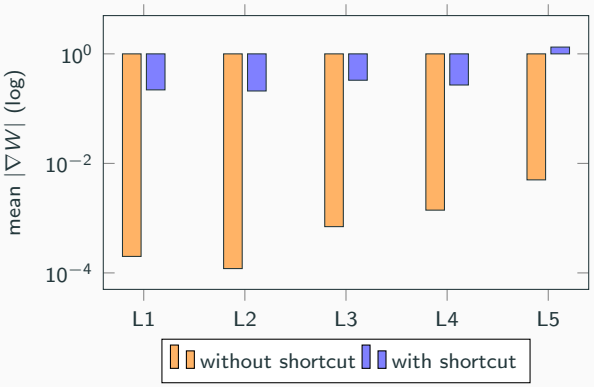
```
class ExampleDeepNeuralNetwork(nn.Module):
def __init__(self, layer_sizes, use_shortcut):
super().__init__()
self.use_shortcut = use_shortcut
self.layers = nn.ModuleList([
nn.Sequential(nn.Linear(layer_sizes[i], layer_sizes[i+1]), GELU())
for i in range(5)])

def forward(self, x):
for layer in self.layers:
layer_output = layer(x)
if self.use_shortcut and x.shape == layer_output.shape:
x = x + layer_output       # shortcut connection
else:
x = layer_output
return x

layer_sizes  = [3, 3, 3, 3, 3, 1]
sample_input = torch.tensor([[1., 0., -1.]])
```

We compute an MSE loss against target 0, call `loss.backward()` and print the **mean absolute gradient** of each layer's weights.

Results: gradients per layer



- **Without** shortcuts: the gradient shrinks from 0.005 (layer 5) to 0.0002 (layer 1) $\Rightarrow$ **vanishing gradient**.
- **With** shortcuts: gradients stay around 0.2–0.3 even in the first layers.
- Shortcuts are a **core building block** of LLMs: they keep gradient flow consistent across dozens of layers.

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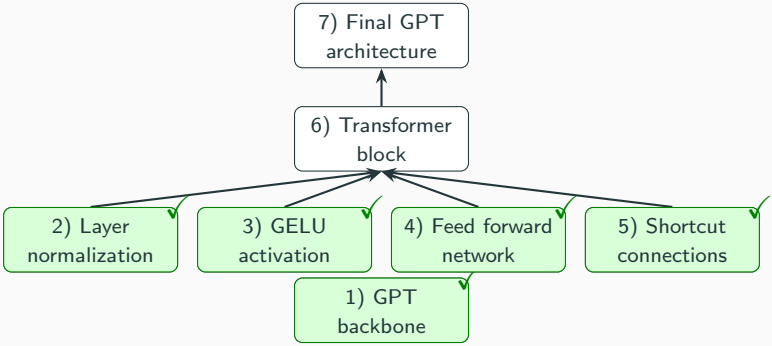
The transformer block

Coding the GPT model

Generating text

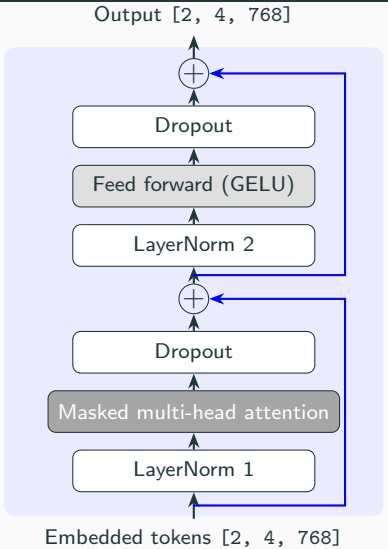
Summary and exercises

Progress so far



Now we combine blocks 2–5 with multi-head attention into a **transformer block**.

Anatomy of the transformer block



- **Self-attention** relates tokens **to each other**.
- **Feed forward** transforms each position **independently**.
- **Pre-LayerNorm**: normalize *before* each sub-layer (GPT-2 and modern LLMs). The original Transformer used *Post-LayerNorm*, with worse training dynamics.
- **Dropout** after each sub-layer for regularization.
- **Shortcut** around each sub-layer.
- Repeated **12 times** in GPT-2 small.

TransformerBlock in code

```
class TransformerBlock(nn
    .Module):
def __init__(self, cfg):
super().__init__()
self.att =
    MultiHeadAttention(
d_in=cfg["emb_dim"],
d_out=cfg["emb_dim"],
block_size=cfg["
    context_length"],
num_heads=cfg["n_heads"],
dropout=cfg["drop_rate"],
qkv_bias=cfg["qkv_bias"])
self.ff = FeedForward(cfg
    )
self.norm1 = LayerNorm(
    cfg["emb_dim"])
self.norm2 = LayerNorm(
    cfg["emb_dim"])
self.drop_resid = nn.
    Dropout(cfg["
    drop_rate"])
```

```
def forward(
    self, x
    ):
# Attention
    sub-
    layer
shortcut = x
x = self.
    norm1(x
    )
x = self.att
    (x)
x = self.
    drop_resid
    (x)
x = x +
    shortcut


# Feed
    forward
     sub-
    layer
shortcut = x
x = self.
    norm2(x
```

Shape preservation

- Input `[2, 4, 768]` $\rightarrow$ output `[2, 4, 768]`.
- This is a **design decision**, not an accident:
  - Blocks can be stacked freely.
  - One output vector per input token (one-to-one).
- The **shape** stays the same, but the **content** changes: each output is a **context vector** that integrates information from the whole (previous) sequence.

$$\underbrace{\mathbf{x}_1, \ldots, \mathbf{x}_n}_{\text{token embeddings}} \xrightarrow{\text{Transformer block}} \underbrace{\mathbf{z}_1, \ldots, \mathbf{z}_n}_{\text{context vectors}}, \qquad \mathbf{x}_i, \mathbf{z}_i \in \mathbb{R}^{768}$$

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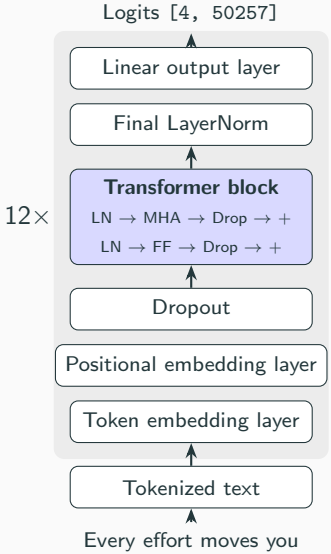
The transformer block

Coding the GPT model

Generating text

Summary and exercises

The full GPT-2 architecture



1. Token IDs → **token embeddings** + **positional embeddings**.
2. Dropout on the embeddings.
3. **12 stacked transformer blocks** (36 in GPT-2 XL*).
4. **Final LayerNorm**.
5. **Linear output head**: 768 → 50,257 (vocabulary size) ⇒ scores for the next token.

*As stated in the book; the original GPT-2 XL has 48 layers (see Exercise 4.2).

GPTModel in code

```
class GPTModel(nn.Module):
def __init__(self, cfg):
super().__init__()
self.tok_emb = nn.Embedding(cfg["vocab_size"], cfg["emb_dim"])
self.pos_emb = nn.Embedding(cfg["context_length"], cfg["emb_dim"])
self.drop_emb = nn.Dropout(cfg["drop_rate"])
self.trf_blocks = nn.Sequential(
*[TransformerBlock(cfg) for _ in range(cfg["n_layers"])])
self.final_norm = LayerNorm(cfg["emb_dim"])
self.out_head = nn.Linear(cfg["emb_dim"], cfg["vocab_size"], bias=False)

def forward(self, in_idx):
batch_size, seq_len = in_idx.shape
tok_embeds = self.tok_emb(in_idx)
pos_embeds = self.pos_emb(torch.arange(seq_len, device=in_idx.device))
x = self.drop_emb(tok_embeds + pos_embeds)
x = self.trf_blocks(x)
x = self.final_norm(x)
logits = self.out_head(x)
return logits
```

Identical to `DummyGPTModel`, with the real `TransformerBlock` and `LayerNorm`.

How many parameters?

```
model =
    GPTModel
    (
    GPT_CONFIG_124M
    )
total_params
     = sum(
    p.numel
    ()
for p in
    model.
    parameters
    ())
# Total
    number
    of
    parameters
    :
    163,009,536
```

Weight tying

The original GPT-2 **reuses the token embedding weights** in the output layer.

$$163{,}009{,}536 - 38{,}597{,}376 = \mathbf{124{,}412{,}160}$$

- Tying reduces memory and compute.
- Separate layers often train better; most modern LLMs do so.
- We revisit tying when loading OpenAI's weights.

Memory footprint

- Each parameter is a 32-bit float = **4 bytes**.

$$\frac{163{,}009{,}536 \times 4 \text{ bytes}}{1024^2} \approx \mathbf{621.83\ MB}$$

- Even a "small" LLM needs significant storage.
- By the same rule, a 175B-parameter model needs $\approx$ **700 GB** in FP32 (just for the weights).
- This motivates lower precision formats (FP16, BF16, INT8, ...).

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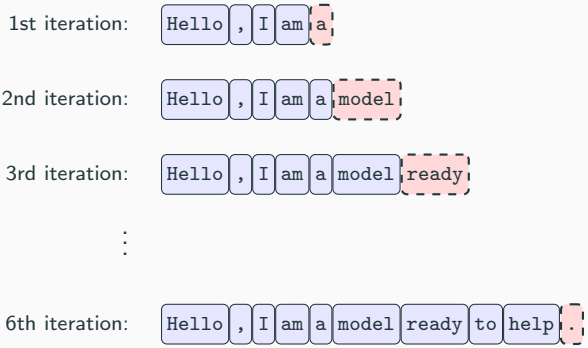
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Generating text

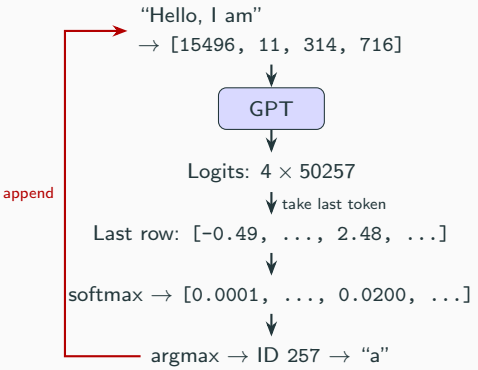
Summary and exercises

Generating one token at a time



The predicted token is **appended** to the input; the context **grows** at each iteration (autoregressive generation).

One generation step in detail



1. Encode text into token IDs.
2. Run the model → logits.
3. Keep the **last** vector (next-token prediction).
4. Softmax → probabilities.
5. Argmax → token ID.
6. Append and repeat.

generate_text_simple

```python
def generate_text_simple(model, idx, max_new_tokens, context_size):
# idx: [batch, n_tokens] array of token IDs in the current context
for _ in range(max_new_tokens):
idx_cond = idx[:, -context_size:]          # crop to supported context
with torch.no_grad():
logits = model(idx_cond)               # [batch, n_tokens, vocab]
logits = logits[:, -1, :]                  # only the last time step
probas = torch.softmax(logits, dim=-1)     # [batch, vocab]
idx_next = torch.argmax(probas, dim=-1, keepdim=True)  # [batch, 1]
idx = torch.cat((idx, idx_next), dim=1)    # append
return idx
```

- Softmax is **monotonic**: argmax over logits gives the same result. Kept for intuition.
- Always choosing the most likely token = **greedy decoding**. Sampling strategies (temperature, top-k) come in the next chapter.

Trying it out

```
start_context = "Hello, I am"
encoded = tokenizer.encode(start_context)          # [15496, 11, 314, 716]
encoded_tensor = torch.tensor(encoded).unsqueeze(0) # add batch dim -> [1, 4]

model.eval()   # disable dropout
out = generate_text_simple(model=model, idx=encoded_tensor,
max_new_tokens=6,
context_size=GPT_CONFIG_124M["context_length"])
print(tokenizer.decode(out.squeeze(0).tolist()))
```

Output

```
Hello, I am Featureiman Byeswickattribute argue logger Normandy ...
```

Gibberish! The model has **random weights**: it has not been **trained** yet $\Rightarrow$ next chapter: pretraining.

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Summary

- **Layer normalization** stabilizes training by giving each layer's outputs a consistent mean and variance.
- **GELU** is a smooth activation used in the **feed forward** module (expand $\times 4$, contract).
- **Shortcut connections** skip layers and mitigate vanishing gradients.
- **Transformer blocks** combine masked multi-head attention and feed forward networks with Pre-LayerNorm, dropout and shortcuts.
- **GPT models** stack many identical transformer blocks; the same `GPTModel` class covers 124M to 1.5B parameters.
- **Text generation** decodes the output one token at a time; without training the output is incoherent.

Exercises

Exercise 4.1 – Parameter counting
Compute and compare the number of parameters in the `FeedForward` module and in the `MultiHeadAttention` module of one transformer block.

Exercise 4.2 – Larger GPT models
Only by changing the configuration, instantiate GPT-2 **medium** (1024-d, 24 layers, 16 heads), **large** (1280-d, 36 layers, 20 heads) and **XL** (1600-d, 48 layers, 25 heads). Bonus: count their parameters.

Exercise 4.3 – Separate dropout rates
Replace the global `drop_rate` with separate values for the embedding dropout, the shortcut dropout and the dropout inside multi-head attention.

Practice: Implementing a GPT model from scratch